MOREH NEVUCHIM

Does God Sit or Stand? Yashav, Kam & Amad — and Moshe's Endless Prophecy

Given Tuesday 14 July 2026 · Moreh Nevuchim I:11-13

Sefer: Moreh Nebuchim (The Guide for the Perplexed) — Rambam; Hebrew text: Rabbi Chaim Makbili's modern translation **Section:** I, Chapters 11, 12, 13 **Topic:** Yashav (sitting), Kimah (rising) and Amidah (standing) — stripping corporeality from the Torah's language about Hashem

Schedule note: Penultimate Moreh shiur before the break — three chapters this week and three next week (Ch. 14–16), moving slightly faster than usual but still in depth.

Recap — Section I So Far

Chapters	Term(s)
1–2	Tzelem Elokim; the sin of Adam
3	Tavnit and Temunah
4	Ra'ah, Hibbit, Chazah — three verbs of seeing
5	Caution when ascending to the Divine
6–7	Ish and Isha; Yalad — giving birth, for man and woman
8	Makom
9	Kisse — chair, throne
10	Alah and Yarad — literal ascent/descent; higher or lower **status**; or directing one's **attention** (up = more important, down = less). Applied to God: "descent" = resting His Shechinah / imparting prophecy; "ascent" = prophecy ending, or punishing humans

This evening: **Yashav** (Ch. 11), **Kimah** (Ch. 12), **Amad** (Ch. 13).

Chapter 11 — Yashav (Sitting)

11.1 Two meanings

Meaning 1 — physical sitting (the original usage):

the term was first fixed in our language for physical sitting — **מונח זה נקבע בתחילה בלשוננו לישיבה פיזית**

As with Eli HaKohen sitting in the Temple when Chana came.

Meaning 2 — borrowed: any stable, permanent, unchanging state:

וכיון שהאדם היושב הוא קבוע ויציב... הושאל המונח לכל מצב יציב וקבוע שאינו משתנה

Since a sitting person is settled and stable in the most complete way, the term was borrowed for any permanent, stable, continuous situation. This is why *yashav* also means **to dwell** — **וישב יעקב בארץ מגורי אביו בארץ כנען** — sitting and dwelling are two different acts, but the same idea of permanence and stability. So Zechariah promises Jerusalem **וישבה תחתיה** — it will be settled, permanent; and in Hallel: **מושיבי עקרת הבית אם הבנים שמחה** — Hashem "seats" the barren woman, i.e. **מעניק לה קביעות ויציבות** — establishes and settles her as a joyful mother of children.

11.2 Applied to Hashem: permanence amid turmoil

אתה ה' לעולם תשב כסאך לדור ודור (Eicha — which we read in a couple of weeks)

Despite all the tragedy, turmoil and chaos of the churban, *You Hashem sit forever* — You are permanent, continuous, stable; Your throne (*kisse* — see Ch. 9) endures generation to generation. Likewise:

> I am going through difficulty, but I lift my eyes to the One who "sits in — **אליך נשאתי את עיני היושבי בשמים** the resha'im scheme, but the — **יושב בשמים ישחק, אדני ילעג למו** .heaven" — the continuous, stable One
> One who sits in heaven laughs — the Permanent One sees through their plans, which will not come to .fruition

11.3 What "He does not change" means — three kinds of no-change

הקיים לעד והיציב שלא משתנה באף פנים מצד שינוי

1. **No intrinsic change (שינוי עצמות):** a person matures, becomes more merciful, kinder — none of this applies to Hashem. Even when we ask Hashem to "move from the throne of din to the throne of rachamim," chas v'shalom to think we are asking God to *change*; we are asking that His current **manifestation** toward us be one of rachamim and chesed rather than din. (The Rambam will discuss this at length.)
2. **No extrinsic change (אין לו מצב מחוץ עצמותו שישתנה בו):** I step into the sun, I become hot and sweat — change caused by external factors, a *mikreh* (recall this concept from our Se'adyah learning: accident/occurrence). No external happening changes Hashem.
3. **No relational change (וגם יחסו לזולתו לא משתנה):** someone smiles at you, you become happy; someone growls, you become upset. **כיוון שאין יחס בינו לבין זולתו שישתנה ביחסו** — verses saying Hashem "becomes happy" or "sad" clearly do not mean change.

ובזאת נשלם — in this sense God is *perfect*: **היותו לא משתנה כלל בשום אופן**, as Malachi says:

כי אני ה' לא שניתי — ואתם בני ישראל לא כליתם

"I Hashem have not changed — and you, Bnei Yisrael, will not perish." Just as He is continuous, so the nation is continuous: individuals go through turmoil, but as a nation — *beli shinuy klal*.

> whenever *yeshiva* is said of Hashem, it means — **במשמעות זו נאמרה ישיבה כאשר היא תיזכר לגביו יתעלה** .this: continuity, stability. The purpose, as throughout these chapters, is removing corporeality

11.4 Why specifically "sitting in heaven"?

וייחס לשמים דווקא לרוב מקומות... משום שהשמים הם אלה שאין בהם שינוי ולא שוני — כלומר שפרטיהם אינם משתנים כמו שמשתנים פרטי הדברים המתהווים והנפסדים בארץ

The Rambam follows the Aristotelian picture: the heavens and celestial bodies are made of different, permanent material — enduring and unchanging — unlike things on earth, which are open to generation and destruction. On earth, Aristotle held, the **species** endure (the human species continues), while the **individuals** within them are born and die. The Nevi'im therefore depict Hashem "sitting in heaven" to convey His permanence, in contradistinction to the changing world below.

Rabbi Twersky's note: today we know this cosmology isn't true — the heavens change just as earthly things do. But that isn't the point: to the naked eye the celestial bodies *appear* the most enduring things we have, and in that sense the verse anchors God's permanence to them.

11.5 "Sitting" even relative to the earth — the species, not the individuals

וכן כאשר יוחס יתעלה... למיני הנמצאות המתהווים והנפסדים — נאמר עליו גם כן יושב, כי מציאות המינים הללו מתמדת, סדורה וקבועה — כמציאות הפרטים בשמים

Hashem can even be compared (as far as a shared *name* allows) to the **species** of earthly things, whose existence is permanent and ordered like the individual bodies of heaven. Hence Yeshaya:

היושב על חוג הארץ — "He who sits upon the circuit of the earth" — **הקיים לעד על טיב כיפת הארץ... כלומר סיבובה, ברמיזה לדברים המתהווים באופן מחזורי**

Not the earth's physical/gravitational rotation (Pines translates "rotation," but they didn't know the earth rotates) — rather the continuous **cycle** of generation, regeneration and death. Individuals are born and perish; the cycle, and the species, endure — and God "sits" over that enduring circuit.

Participant question (Mark): but species *do* go extinct — so they're not enduring? **Answer:** (a) This is Aristotle's conceptual framework, which the Rambam is working within; the concept of relative endurance is the point, not its scientific accuracy today (we now know there's no material difference between celestial bodies and earthly things at all). (b) Looking more broadly, even where a specific kind became extinct, the larger family continues — the point is the perpetual circuit of things coming into the world.

11.6 ה' למבול ישב — the Friday-night verse

ה' למבול ישב וישב ה' מלך לעולם

What can "Hashem *sat* at the flood" mean? **כלומר שגם כאשר מצבי הארץ משתנים ונהרסים — אצלו יתעלה יחסו לכלל הדבר היחס שווה** — even amid the flood's total destruction, Hashem endures; and moreover, **המתהווה וכלה הוא יחס אחד יציב וקבוע — כיחסו למיני הדברים המתהווים ולא לפרטיהם** — His relationship is with the **categories** of created things, and that relationship is stable even while individuals perish. The created order and its governance endure through the chaos.

בכלל: כל לשון ישיבה שתמצא מיוחס להשם — read it this way everywhere (including, implicitly, the "sitting on the throne" of Yechezkel's vision — throne in Ch. 9, sitting here; the picture is assembling).

11.7 Rav Kook's beautiful application — Acher and Metatron (Chagiga)

Angels **stand** — this is behind the minhag (brought in Shulchan Aruch: **יש שנוהגים כל היום והלילה**) to stand on Yom Kippur, resembling the angels. Why do angels stand and never sit? By this chapter it makes perfect sense: only Hashem "sits" — only He is true permanence; even angels, in the domain of God, are transient and unstable relative to Him.

Now the famous Gemara — four entered the *pardes* (the orchard = intellectual apprehension of God), and Acher (Elisha ben Avuya) **קיצץ בנטיעות** — cut the plants, speculated incorrectly. What exactly did he do

wrong?

חזא מיטטרון דאיתיהיבא ליה רשותא למיתב, למכתב זכוותא דישראל. אמר: גמירא דלמעלה לא הוי לא ישיבה ולא תחרות... שמא חס ושלום שתי רשויות הן

He saw Metatron — who had been *given permission* to sit — sitting and writing the merits of Israel, and said: we have a tradition there is no sitting above — perhaps there are two authorities! And he became a heretic. On our chapter this is exquisite: Acher saw in an angel's **sitting** a claim of *permanence* — and permanence belongs to God alone; hence "two reshuyot."

And note **what** Metatron was writing: the merits of Am Yisrael. Recall the Malachi verse the Rambam quoted — **אני ה' לא שניתי ואתם בני ישראל לא כליתם**. The greatest permanence in existence aside from God is the continuity, the immutability, of Am Yisrael. Perhaps that is the pshat in why Metatron sat *for this task*: the sitting denotes the permanence of the nation whose merits he records. Acher could not absorb that — and he cut the plants.

Aside: this is also why we speak of **יושב בדין** — a judge sits in judgment: judgment requires the calm, settled steadiness that sitting embodies, not merely the physical posture.

11.8 Chapter 11 summary

Yashav has two meanings: literal sitting, and figurative stability/permanence/continuity. With Hakadosh Baruch Hu it always means the second: no intrinsic, extrinsic or relational change. Hence "sitting in heaven" (the heavens symbolise permanence against the changing world below) and "sitting at the flood" (individuals perish; His governance and the order of creation endure). Purpose: removing any corporeal "sitting" from God.

Chapter 12 — Kimah (Rising)

12.1 Four meanings

קימה מונח רב־משמעי

Meaning 1 — physical rising, the opposite of sitting (**שכנגד הישיבה**):

וכל עבדי המלך... לא קם ולא זע ממנו, וימלא המן על מרדכי חמה

Mordechai neither rose (*lo kam*) nor even stirred (*lo za*) — not even the small *hidur*, the slight lift of recognition when someone passes; certainly not full standing.

Meaning 2 — establishment / fulfilment of a matter (קיום הדבר ונכונותו):

יקם ה' את דברו — Elkanah to Chana: Hashem must *fulfil* His word. (Context: Chana had been blessed with Shmuel, who by Hashem's word through Eli was to be dedicated to the Mikdash. Elkanah set out for aliyah la'regel; Chana said she must stay until the child is weaned; Elkanah agreed — stay, "only may Hashem fulfil His word.")

ויקם שדה עפרון... לאברהם למקנה — the field "arose" to Avraham: no standing up — it became **legally established** as his.

וקם הבית אשר בעיר... לצמיתת לקנה אתו לדרתיו (Behar) — a house in a walled city not repurchased within the year becomes permanently, legally established to the buyer.

וקם... ממלכת ישראל — the kingdom will be *established*.

Meaning 3 — resolving to act; rising up against, rebelling:

וכיוון שהמחליט לעשות דבר כלשהו יוצא אל מעשה ידי קימה... נאמר על כל מי שמתקומם כנגד אדם שהוא קם

One who resolves to act *gets up* to do it; hence "rising against" someone: **כי הקים בני את עבדי עלי** — Shaul: my son (Yonatan) has "raised" David against me — not stood him up, not established him: made him **rebel**, take action against me.

Meaning 4 — the extension of 3, borrowed for God: executing decreed punishment:

המשמעות הזו הושאלה לביצוע צו השם באנשים שנגזר עליהם עונש לעונשן

וקמתי על בית ירבעם — I will "rise" against the house of Yerovam = I will take action, punish.

וקם על בית מרעים — He will rise against the house of evildoers.

(The Rabbi suggested you can equally frame these as 3a and 3b: rising-up-against in the human context, and in the God context = rising to execute judgment.)

12.2 With Hashem: always meaning 2 or 4 — never physical

במשמעות הזו נאמר כל לשון קימה על השם יתעלה

עתה אקום יאמר ה' — "Now I will arise" = **אקיים בעת... את דברי והבטחותיי ואיומיי** — now I fulfil what I have said: promises, or warnings and punishments.

אתה תקום תרחם ציון כי עת לחננה — You will "arise" and have mercy on Zion = **תקיים מה שהבטחת להתרחם עליה** — You will fulfil Your promise of mercy.

And the Rambam adds: **וייתכן שדבריו אלה שהזכיר "עתה אקום" — במשמעות זו** — perhaps those very verses can instead be read by meaning 4: *now I will arise* — **עתה ארומם עתה אנשא** — now I punish; and **אתה תקום תרחם ציון** — You will rise against her enemies and take them down. Either way — 2 or 4; never 1:

לא שיש לו יתעלה קימה וישיבה... אמרו עליהם השלום: אין למעלה לא ישיבה ולא עמידה

There is no sitting or standing Above (the Gemara; and *amidah* is sometimes said in place of *kum* — the terms interchange).

12.3 Shem Tov: why is punishment called "rising"?

Shem Tov (15th-century Spanish commentary on the Moreh): the natural order of the world is **good** — recall the previous idea: sitting is the stable, natural state; standing is the change. When Hashem "stands," He is — so to speak — breaking the stable natural goodness of the world; hence rising = the departure from the norm that punishment represents.

12.4 The Rabbi's question: why didn't the Rambam bring קומה ה'?

Is there not a *perfect* Torah verse for meaning 4 — Hashem arising to execute judgment on the wicked? From Beha'alotcha, said by Ashkenazim when opening the Aron:

ויהי בנסע הארן ויאמר משה: קומה ה' ויפצו איביך וינסו משנאיך מפניך

Ibn Ezra, immediately bothered by it, comments: **כדרך בני אדם המדברים** — metaphoric: as humans rise to fight, "rise, Hashem, and fight our enemies." So why did the Rambam not bring this superb source?

Suggested answer: perhaps the Rambam understood **קומה ה'** there as referring to the **cloud** — the physical Ananei HaKavod that literally rose and moved when the camp set out to travel and fight. If the verse

describes a genuinely *physical* ascent (of the cloud), it cannot serve as proof for the non-physical meaning — so it is unhelpful for his purpose, and he leaves it out.

12.5 Aside: the order of the Rambam's proof-verses

Note the Rambam jumps from Shmuel to Bereishit to Vayikra — seemingly out of order. As we have seen over the years (and as the Abarbanel and the commentaries discuss at length on this chapter), there is always a deliberate order in the Moreh's citations; it is beyond the scope of the shiur, but be aware nothing here is haphazard.

12.6 Chapter 12 summary

Kam has four meanings: (1) physically rising; (2) establishing/fulfilling (legal title, promises); (3) rising up against someone (humans); (4) — the borrowed extension to God — rising to execute decreed judgment. With Hashem it is always 2 or 4, never physical: continuing the rejection of corporeality.

Chapter 13 — Amidah (Standing)

13.1 Three meanings — and a deep fourth application

עמידה מונח רב־משמעי

Meaning 1 — physical standing (קימה ועמידה):

ויוסף בן שלשים שנה בעמדו לפני פרעה — Yosef, from prison, now *stands* before Pharaoh.

אם יעמד משה ושמואל לפני — Hashem to Yirmiyahu: even if Moshe and Shmuel *stood* (from their graves) in prayer before Me, I would not forgive.

והוא עמד עליהם תחת העץ ויאכלו — (Vayera) Avraham standing over the three angels as they eat.

Why is Vayera brought last, out of order? Because for the Rambam the entire episode of the angels occurred **in a vision** — no one ever physically stood over angels on a piece of earth. It is therefore the *weakest* proof of physical standing, and he deliberately places it last. (A good example of the deliberate ordering we noted in Ch. 12 — though we won't chase this every time.)

Meaning 2 — cessation, stopping (הימנעות והפסקה):

Why? Because when you stop walking — you stand.

כי עמדו לא ענו עוד — (Iyov) Elihu began speaking only when the friends had *stopped* answering.

ותעמד מלדת — (Vayetzei) Leah, after Yehuda, *stopped* giving birth.

Meaning 3 — permanence, endurance, posterity (קביעות וקיום):

ונתתם בכלי חרש למען יעמדו ימים רבים — (Yirmiyahu) place the deeds in an earthenware vessel so they will *last* many days.

אם את הדבר הזה תעשה... ויכלת עמד — (Yitro) delegate to ministers of thousands, hundreds, fifties and tens, "and you will be able to *stand*" — not physically; you will be able to **continue**, sustainably, without burning out.

עמד טעמו בו — Moav's "taste has stood": it has *lasted*, undisturbed, until now (and now Hashem will change that).

צדקתו עמדת לעד — the tzaddik's righteousness *stands* forever — **קבועה וקיימת**, enduring for posterity.

13.2 With Hashem: always meaning 3

כל עמידה שנאמרה לגבי השם יתעלה — המשמעות הזאת אחרונה

Never 1 (no physicality), never 2 (no stopping) — always permanence and continuity. Three verses to analyse:

(a) Zechariah — ועמדו רגליו ביום ההוא על הר הזיתים — "His legs will stand that day on Har HaZeitim." **ותהיינה סיבותיו קבועות** — His *consequences* will be fixed and enduring. The Rambam will explain in I:28 that *regel*, certainly in the context of God, means **consequence and impact** — your legs extend out from you; they are your reach into the world. So the verse means: in the messianic age, God's impacts — the recognition of His presence and providence — will be constant, enduring, visible day in and day out. **דבר זה עוד יתבאר** (Ch. 28).

(b) ואתה פה עמד עמדי (Va'etchanan) — Hashem to Moshe: "You, stand here with Me."

Probably 99% of us have always read this as physical standing — and what would even be wrong with *Moshe* standing? **The problem:** if it means literal standing *with Me*, it attributes **spatial context** to Hakadosh Baruch Hu — a "place" beside God to stand in. Therefore the Rambam reads meaning 3: **you will be continuously with Me** — a permanent, uninterrupted prophetic bond.

This is exactly the Rambam in Mishneh Torah on the uniqueness of Moshe's prophecy (one of the distinctions we discussed last year):

> **כל הנביאים אין מתנבאים בכל עת שירצו — משה רבינו אינו כן, אלא בכל זמן שיחפוץ רוח הקודש לובשתו... שהרי הוא מכוון ומזומן ועומד... ובזה הבטיחו האל, שנאמר: לך אמר להם שובו לכם לאהליכם — ואתה פה עמד עמדי**

All other prophets prophesy only when Hashem wills; Moshe — whenever he wished, because he is perpetually prepared, directed, **standing ready**. At Har Sinai the others were sent home — **שובו לכם לאהליכם** — but Moshe: *stand here with Me* — remain in continuous prophetic dialogue. **הא למדת שכל הנביאים... חוזרים לאהליהם — ומשה רבינו לא חזר לאהלו הראשון, לפיכך פירש מן האשה לעולם** — which is why Moshe separated from his wife permanently: the dialogue never stopped.

(c) אנכי עמד בין ה' וביניכם בעת ההוא להגיד לכם את דבר ה' — Moshe: "I *stood* between Hashem and you at that time." Again, physical standing "between" would attribute spatial context to God. Meaning 3: **I am the continuous conduit** — the permanent intermediary passing on the word of Hashem.

13.3 Makbili's deeper point: Moshe as the permanent conduit between God and humanity

Rabbi Makbili suggests the Rambam is teaching something deeper in verse (c) — Moshe is the **standing**, permanent channel between God and humanity, with three implications:

1. **The world cannot function without Torat Moshe** — the continuous conduit is constitutive, not historical.
2. **All prophets receive their koach ha'nevuah through Moshe** — as the Rambam writes elsewhere.
3. **Even a non-Jew's Torah is Torat Moshe.** The famous (and famously hard) Rambam: the Gemara says a non-Jew earns a portion in the World to Come by keeping the seven Noahide laws — on which basis most of humanity would qualify. But the Rambam adds, of his own accord (*svara d'nafshei*, as the Beit Yosef notes):

> **כל המקבל שבע מצות ונזהר לעשותן הרי זה מחסידי אומות העולם ויש לו חלק לעולם הבא — והוא שיקבל אותן ויעשה אותן מפני שצוה בהן הקדוש ברוך הוא בתורה, והודיענו על ידי משה רבינו שבני נח מקודם נצטוו**

בהן. אבל אם עשאן מפני הכרע הדעת — אין זה גר תושב ואינו מחסידי אומות העולם, אלא מחכמיהם

Only one who keeps the sheva mitzvot *because Hashem commanded them in the Torah through Moshe* is of the **chasidei** umot ha'olam with a chelek in Olam Haba; one who keeps them from reason alone is of their **chachamim** — wise, but not pious. Where the Rambam derived this is a vast discussion — but on Makbili's reading it flows from our verse: *all* morality and connection to God passes through the standing conduit — **אנכי עמד בין ה' וביניכם**.

13.4 Chapter 13 summary

Amad means (1) physical standing, (2) stopping, or (3) permanence/endurance. In relation to Hashem it always signifies (3): His enduring actions and consequences (Zechariah — the messianic age); and of Moshe "standing" with/before God — the constant, never-interrupted prophetic relationship and his permanent role as intermediary of Am Yisrael.

Summary of the Evening

- **Ch. 11 — Yashav:** to sit; borrowed for stability, permanence, continuity. With God — always the second: no intrinsic, extrinsic or relational change (**אני ה' לא שניתי**). "Sitting in heaven" borrows the (Aristotelian) permanence of the celestial realm; "sitting on the circuit of the earth" and "at the flood" — His enduring relationship with the *species* and order of creation even as individuals perish. Rav Kook's read of Acher and the seated Metatron: sitting = permanence, which belongs to God (and, through the merits Metatron records, to the immutable Am Yisrael) — misread by Acher as a second authority.
- **Ch. 12 — Kam:** (1) rising (Mordechai); (2) establishing/fulfilling (Efron's field; the walled city; יקם ה' את דברו); (3) rising against (Yonatan "raising" David); (4) with God — executing decreed judgment (בית ירבעם). With Hashem: always 2 or 4. Shem Tov: punishment is "standing" because it departs from the world's stable natural goodness. Why no קומה ה' ויפצו אויביך? Likely because there it is the cloud physically rising — useless as proof.
- **Ch. 13 — Amad:** (1) standing (Yosef; the vision of Vayera deliberately last as the weakest proof); (2) stopping (Elihu; Leah); (3) enduring (Yitro's ויכלת עמד; צדקתו עומדת לעד). With God — always 3: His consequences (*raglav* = impacts, see I:28) endure in the messianic age; **ואתה פה עמד עמדי** — Moshe's continuous, ever-ready prophecy (hence separating from his wife); **אנכי עמד בין ה' וביניכם** — Moshe the permanent conduit, through whom all prophecy, all Torah, and (per the famous Rambam on chasidei umot ha'olam) even the Noahide path must pass.

Coming Up

Next week — the final Moreh shiur before the break: three more chapters. **Chapter 14 — Adam** (huge chapter, extremely short — the short ones are the big ones): what does *Adam* mean, now that we know *Ish* and *Isha*? Plus **Nitzav** (standing — yet another kind) and **Tzur** (rock). Then we break.

Summer avodah from the Rabbi: over the summer, when reading pesukim — on Shabbat, when davening alone, when there's more time to think — look out for the terms we've learned these past months, and apply the Rambam's meanings in context.

B'Ezrat Hashem

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